A disappointed diaspora

Here I would like to sum up what I had gathered from my personal meetings and phone conversations with my friends, contacts and relatives during my ten days in Canada and the US. All of them enquired as to what happened to their suggestions (which they had made during my first visit in December 1981, and which are mentioned in Chapter 3). They emphasized again their anguish at the continued irresponsible and biased coverage of Punjab by the Indian media, especially the vernacular press, which was fanning communalism in Punjab and widening the schism between Hindus and Sikhs in their respective countries too.

They drew my attention towards the killing of innocent Hindus in Punjab and the Haryana police's repression of Sikhs. They informed me that gurudwaras in the US and Canada were increasingly coming under the control of hard-line Sikhs; there was a lack or total absence of institutional support from Indian missions in their respective areas or countries to help maintain cordial relations between Hindus and Sikhs. They were quite frank in saying that it seemed that Bhindranwale was being encouraged by some senior Congress leaders for political gains, which in turn was helping the pro-Khalistan elements in Canada and the US to attract Sikh youth towards their ideology.

I had no convincing answer to their questions as to what had happened to their suggestions made to me in December 1981. Actually, by then I had realized that what they were saying was largely true, especially about the root cause of the worsening situation in Punjab, but could not openly express my views because of my official position. By the time I finished my visit I had got the impression that if the situation in Punjab did not improve, which I felt it would not till the next parliamentary elections, very few of my contacts and friends from those two countries would meet me or talk to me again on that subject. None of them was a paid source. What they were sharing with me was out of friendship and their concern for the deteriorating situation in Punjab and its impact on their lives in the countries they had settled in.